The week before, two rounds of talks were held between the central government and the farmers' unions but had yet again remained inconclusive. Many of the unions were accepting of the government's proposal to put the implementation of the laws on hold for 18 months and make further progress in deliberations. However, they were silenced and disallowed from discussing their satisfaction with the government's proposal in the media. Out of the 32 unions from Punjab, over 15 wanted to accept the government's proposal and call off the protests in an open vote which took place in their union leaders' meet.[21]

Although the rally was only permitted to start after the Republic Day parade, the protestors in violation of the guidelines started early. What was promised to be a peaceful march quickly began to turn violent when confrontations between the Delhi Police and protestors broke out because the latter diverged from the permissible routes. The rogue protestors attacked police busses and broke barricades, almost running over several men in uniform on duty trying to stop them. In response, the police used tear gas and batons to control the unruly crowd.[22] The SKM proudly declared, 'We have broken the barricades, we have our tractors, people are marching, some leaders are also on horseback…thousands of farmers have already reached the capital. Outside the Delhi police headquarters tear gas and batons were used, protestors also attacked the police buses stationed there.'[23]

High-speed tractors rammed down multiple police barricades which were put up to stop the crowd making its way towards the Red Fort. Protestors on horsebacks used weapons like swords, kirpans and fursas to attack the policemen who attempted to stop them. In response to the violence, which went out of the Delhi Police's hand, Home Minister Amit Shah deployed paramilitary forces. About 400 policemen suffered injuries. Despite all efforts to stop the rioting mob, several hundred reached the Red Fort, where they climbed on the ramparts, mounted poles and hoisted a yellow flag with an emblem in the centre which some groups believe was the Nishan Sahib (religious Sikh community) flag while others confirm it to be a Khalistani (extremist Sikh separatist group) flag.[24]

After the episode it became clear that the protesting movement at the borders of New Delhi was no longer one which prioritized farmers' concerns, but one which had deep-vested interests to unsettle peace in the national capital. The SKM distanced itself from the violence claiming that